Universität Zürich[UZH]

Small Communities and Anonymization- Challenges in Data Protection in Qualitative Research

Dr. Rebekka Rieser
07 February 2025

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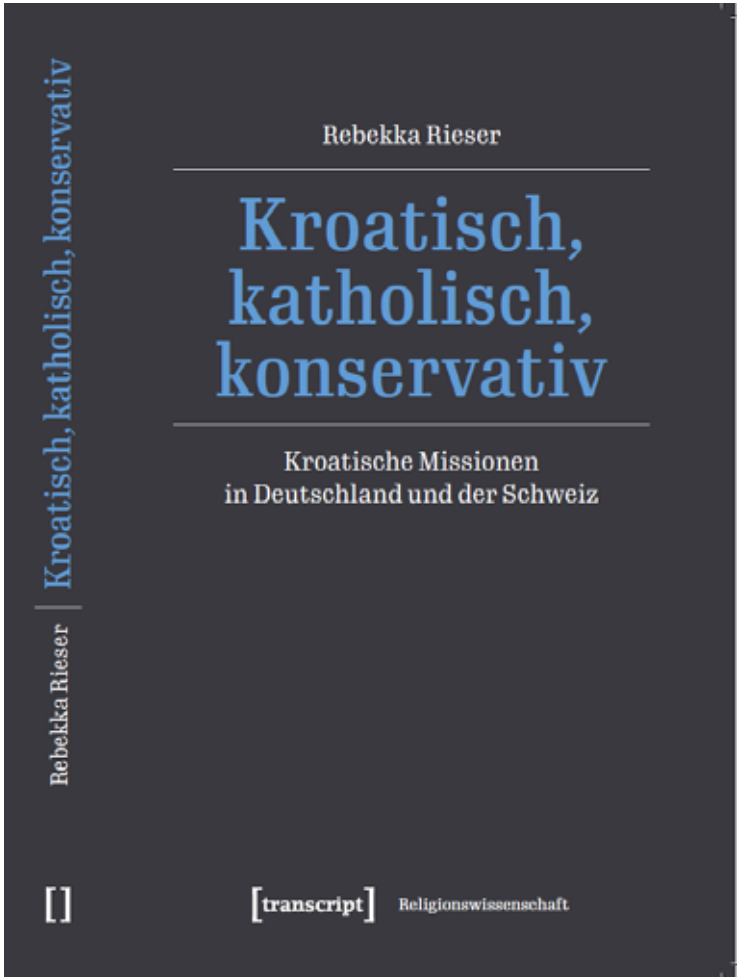
Why am I here?



How to do meaningful research and protect data in qualitative research and especially in small communities?

The Research Project in a Nutshell

Project and Research Aims

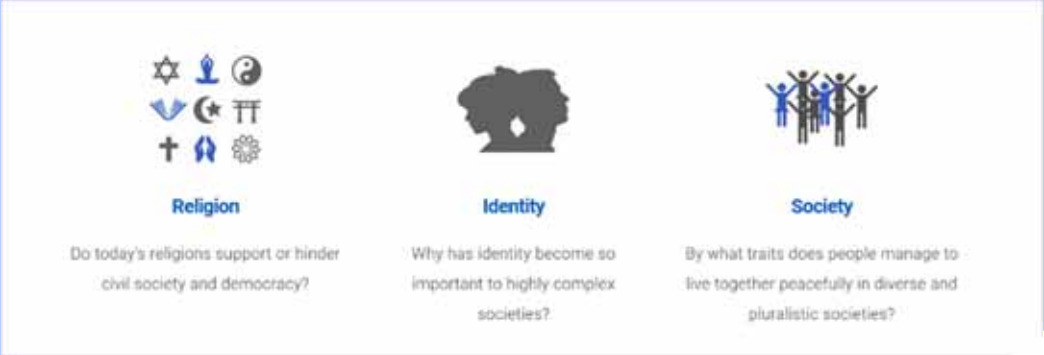
- «Religious and Social Identity in Civil Society»
- SNF /DFG Lead-Agency project (2018-2021)
- Two sub-projects
  - “Migrant Communities, Religious Identities and Integration in Civil Society (MIE)”
  - “Configurations of Individual and Collective Identities and their Potentials in Civil Society: Representative Results for Germany and Switzerland in Comparison (KONID)”

RESIC

Research Aims

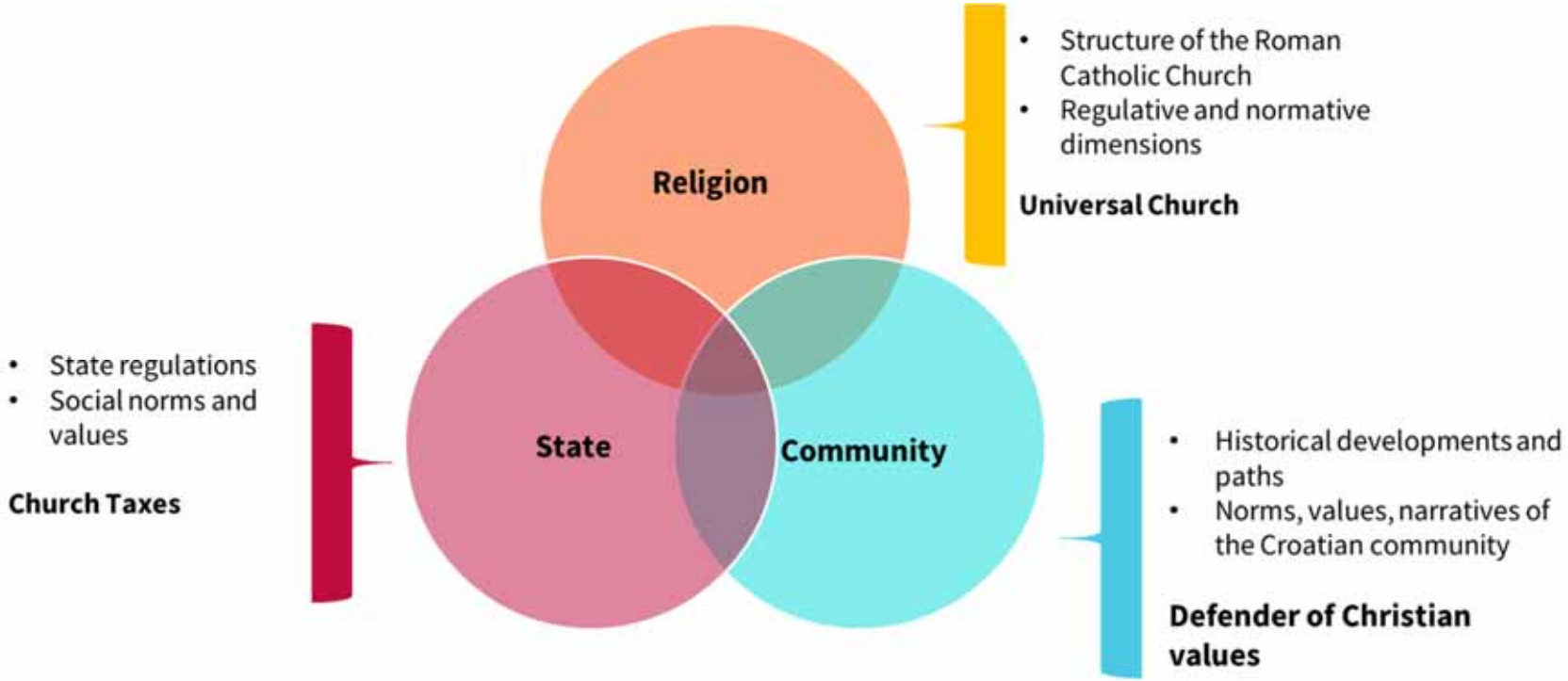
"The project “Social Groups and Religious Identities in Civil Society (RESIC)” investigates the structure and prerequisites of social identities, the impact of religious immigrant communities on the individual and organizational level as well as the overall causal effects of religious social identities in civil society and politics. “ (A. Liedhegener)

"We expect from the research new findings on adapted self-presentations of religious immigrants communities in view of the socially constructed myth of a "good religion”.” (M. Baumann)



Theoretical frames and research questions

RQ:
What are the expectations and roles of religious organizations in the diaspora and what are the consequences for the community, society and the individual?



cf. e.g: Lambert, 2014; Pollack et al, 2014; Stolz et al, 2014; Zurlinden, 2015

Investigated Areas

- Individual Practices and Memberships in Clubs
- Individual Political Behavior
- Individual Religiosity and Practices
- Migration Biography / History
- Community History
- Collective Identity, Religiosity, and Practices
- Organizational Structures and Roles
- Organizational Environments

Sample and Data

Field

- Two each in Switzerland (de / fr) / Two each in Germany
- Two in larger cities / Two in more rural areas
- 40 interviews (33 members and 7 with priests)

Topic-focused Interviews

- Guided for the priests
- Guide for the members

Structured Qualitative Content Analysis

- Deductive approach: e.g. expectation management, legitimacy,
- Inductive approach: e.g.: Charity, holidays

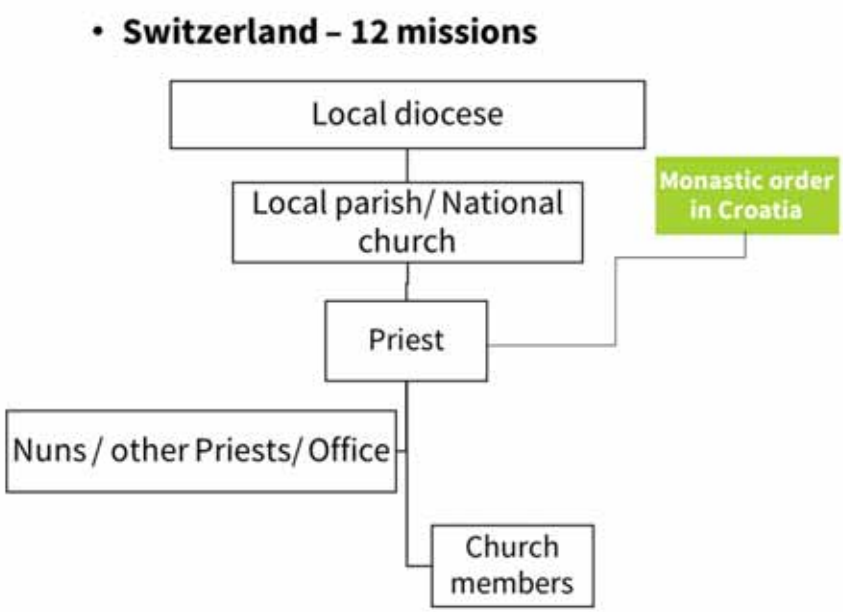
The Challenge

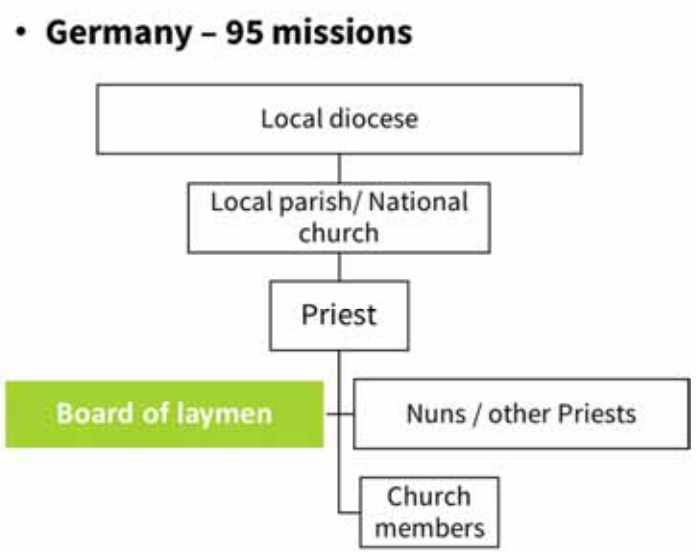
Sensitive Areas?

Individual Practices and Memberships in Clubs	• Names of Clubs, Dates, Descriptions of Clubs […]
Individual Political Behavior	• Party Affiliation
Individual Religiosity and Practices	• Description of «Religious Routine»
Migration Biography / History	• Geographical Touchpoints, Biographical and Historical Key events, Dates […]
Community History	• Geographical Locations, Dates, Historical Key events […]
Collective Identity, Religiosity, and Practices	• Time, Locations, Descriptions of Others […]
Organizational Structures and Roles	• Locations, Names of Others, Hierarchical Dependencies […]
Organizational Environments	• Locations, Dates, Name of Others, Descritiption of Neighborhoods […]

Croatian Diaspora – a very small communtiy and a strict hierarchy

- Approx. 63,000 Croatians in Switzerland and 414,000 Croatians in Germany (see SBK /RKZ 2019, Graf 2019)
- The Croatian missions are a sub-organization of the Roman Catholic Church in DE and CH





Data Protection

Measures

Declaration of Consent
- Signature
- Verbal confirmation

Digital Encryption
- Cloud / NAS
- Passwords

Anonymization
- Data Description
- Interviews

Rebekka Rieser, MA.
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Einverständniserklärung

_____ (Vorname, Name) erklärt sich damit einverstanden, dass seine/ihre Daten im Rahmen der Dissertation von Rebekka Rieser und des Forschungsprojektes «Religious and Social Identity in Civil Society» der Universität Luzern erhoben und gespeichert werden. Dazu zählen schriftliche und auch auditive Daten.

Es werden keine Daten an Drittpersonen weitergegeben. Die Auswertung der Interviews und andere erhobene Daten erfolgt anonymisiert, so dass keine Zuordnung der Daten zur Person möglich ist. Zitationen erfolgen ebenfalls nur anonymisierter Form.

Alle Daten werden nur zur Auswertungszwecken gespeichert und unterstehen dem schweizerischen Bundesgesetzt über den Datenschutz (DSG), SR 235.1.

Mit meiner Unterschrift stimme ich der Speicherung des Interviews in digitaler Form zu rein wissenschaftlichen Zwecken zu.

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Good Examples

1 B: Um (...) I think that everything that is done in the congregation, um, just in terms of the church service and how people are with each other, I think it's quite similar. What I think makes this congregation special, which is also a difference, in Croatia below it's all Croats and um, in a village it's all Croats, and in a village everyone comes to the village church and it's just that not everyone from [town in Switzerland] comes to this church now, but there are also people, who come from [big city in Switzerland], who come from [city in Switzerland] and what makes this community special, I think, are these events that are organized to promote cohesion, because they are all a bit spread out, not all in one place, like in Croatia now. Um, yes, I just think it's nice that they try to stick together, to show: "Hey, look, we're more than just this here now", um, yes, so just (.) that they try to bring everything together, all in one place (.) and so yes. (..) #00:17:17-8#

I: Are you still planning to maybe join a club here in Switzerland? #00:30:52-5#

G: I would like to, but [proper name university] takes up my free time. I'm trying to play at least [sport] with my friend or go to the gym. That's- or sometimes go to the movies but yes that's […]

Critical Examples

B: Mhm. Yes, so my name is [proper name] and I was born in 1980. I moved to Switzerland during the war in my home country, Croatia. Because my father worked there, didn't he? And uh before I needed (hobby) ne? Because I also worked in the Franciscan monastery in [Swiss city] //Mhm.//. I wanted to become a priest myself, didn't I?

B: I was born in Switzerland in 1992. My parents arrived in Switzerland at the end of the 1980s, in 1987, 1988. They were working as seasonal workers at the time. That means they worked at certain times of the year and then returned to Croatia.

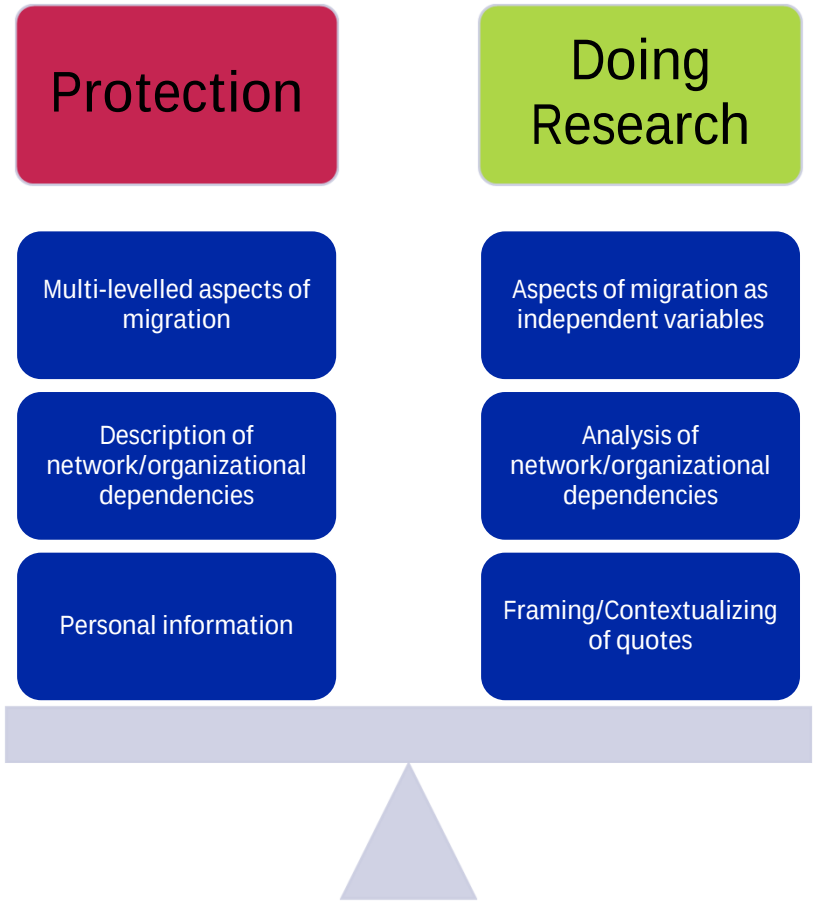
G: No, unfortunately not. I used to - I was in a robot club or whatever you call it and even before that I was - I mean I built robots for a few years. And that's actually my connection with technology and I was also in a sports club for a few years and was the fourth best in Croatia.

Challenges with Quotes

If we do not succeed in recognizing the signs of the times, then that will thus-. […] the whole holy history is the history of migration. There, so the God from Abraham to Moses to Jesus, who also had to flee and so on […]. God leads his people […] So we probably won't be able to do that with our human rules and laws. But I think the story of salvation is still valid. So all the migrants, it has a purpose. We may see it all the way through in the generations after us. **“Priest (Coordinator), 1950, Gen. 1, GE”**

Learnings and Conclusions

Opportunity costs – finding a balance



And..

Individuals between private persons and official roles

Ethical dilemma in finding answers in letting them tell their stories but possible professional consequences

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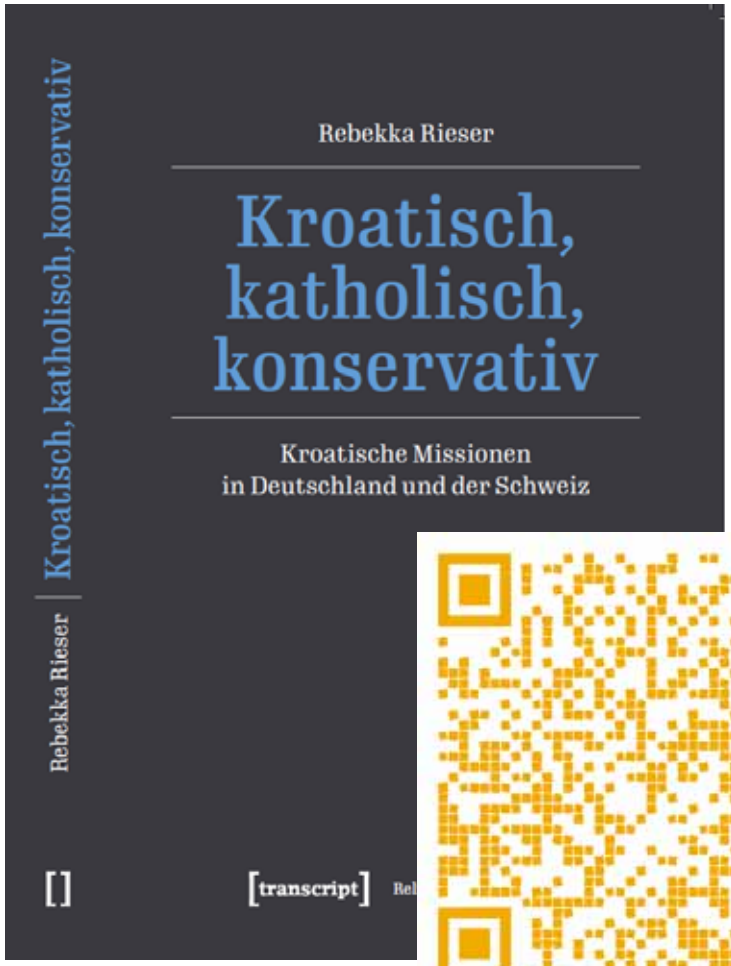
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